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Sufism as World Literature

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The Inseparability of Love and Poetry Reflected Through Sufism

Compared to last week, I spent about roughly ten hours on reading and analyzing the materials for this class. It was enriching to read about love, not only for our beloved ones, but also for God. In a time associated with finding the perfect partner and a lot of psychology centered around dating, having love for the divine is truly a very different phenomenon. Perhaps it would be wrong to put that way, because what Sufi poets felt about their love to God cannot be described in simple words.

I have a sense that two heavy reading classes might be quite hard to digest; however, I am enjoying what I am reading in both of my classes – one is about Sufism and the other about International Development – both of them are relevant to my identity and interests. Usually, I spend roughly six to ten hours on reading materials, just like for this class. I like to read early in the morning starting from 6 am when I am fresh.

Unlike what I've been taught about Allah in Islam (often praying and fasting), it is a unique way of looking at the relationship between a servant and God in a metaphysical way. How could the whole universe be a reflection of God? I often pondered. For my liberal mind, it is a very controversial and deep way of thinking. How could one love God to the extent that all other possibilities are unreal? The concept of separation and return in Sufi Islam could teach us

about uniting with the ‘other’ that extends beyond physical self. In Sufi Islam, there is no separation from God, because He exists in all forms of existence. If the servant has committed a wrongdoing, there is still an opportunity to purify himself, because the dynamic relationship with God never ends. That means, if the servant seeks forgiveness (*tawbah*), God forgives him. The divine love of God given to his servants is powerful in Islam, and all other forms of love, according to the podcast, are worldly attachments, therefore mistaken forms of love. Worldly desires, such as one’s love for money, are misinterpretations of love, as God’s love should be sought throughout one’s life. If a bad event happens in one’s life, it does not mean God’s love for the servant has weakened or ended; it means, it is a testament of God’s love. When Sufis say that servants should seek purification, it does not reflect only in a physical sense, but also in one’s inner sense. These can include Islamic laws, like frequently asking oneself about their actions in daily life and whether they are morally, ethically good. This also includes searching for knowledge (*marifa*), for the ultimate truth, which is part of the servant’s spiritual journey.

I liked how poems we read for Thursday were easy to read and follow; each of them showing a Muslim’s love for God through admiration, adoring, and as the greatest need. As we read in, “What is World Literature?” It is hard to get the gist of books from other cultures, because the foreign reader lacks specific knowledge of that culture and place. However, in those poems, we do not need to know a particular person or place, since they are purely about God. Indeed, the reading about Rabi’a could be somewhat challenging due to a lot of names and events to keep track of. The narratives of Rabi’a were very different from each other; in one case, she rejects all forms of love in this world, because for her, she seeks only God’s love. In another story, she is an actual wife. How could the believers of one religion have vastly different

interpretations of her? Does time and place matter for literature if we consider religious texts as literary work?